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THA 101: Traditional African Theatre - Festival, Ritual and Performance

Read African festival theatre as a complete performance system, not as folklore

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

THA 101 is where the department teaches you that African theatre did not begin with a written script. This pack explains festival theatre as a total performance event - space, audience, music, costume, masquerade and participation - and shows you how to describe a performance you have witnessed with precision instead of vague praise.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define traditional African theatre and distinguish it from written dramatic literature.
- Analyse a festival performance using space, audience, performer, music, costume and participation.
- Explain how ritual structure shapes the organisation of an African festival.
- Describe the masquerade tradition without treating it as mere entertainment.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What counts as traditional African theatre

Traditional theatre is performance made by a community, for that community, in a form inherited and adapted rather than written down by a single author.

- The performance is usually tied to a calendar, a rite of passage or a season, not to a ticketed evening.
- Text may be minimal; meaning is carried by movement, music, mask, costume and audience response.
- There is no sharp line between performers and spectators: the community participates.
- The performance often has a social function - purification, harvest thanksgiving, initiation, conflict resolution.

- Continuity comes from apprenticeship and participation, not from published scripts.

> **Avoid two mistakes**
> Do not treat African festival theatre as primitive entertainment, and do not romanticise it as untouched tradition. It changes with its community and has always absorbed new elements.

Festival as total theatre

Total theatre means every performance element carries meaning at once.

- Space: the market square, shrine, compound or village green is the stage, and its meaning changes the performance.
- Music: drums and song cue entrances, control tempo and mark transitions.
- Costume and mask: they identify status, spirit or character, and may transform the wearer.
- Movement and dance: patterned movement carries narrative and community identity.
- Audience: response, chorus and participation complete the performance.
- Time: festivals often run for days, so duration itself is part of the form.

Writing about a performance

Assessment rewards specific observation. Use this structure for any performance report.

1. State what you saw, where and on what occasion.
2. Describe the performance space and how it was used.
3. Identify performers, costumes and masks, and what each communicated.
4. Analyse music and movement as structural devices, not decoration.
5. Describe audience participation and how it shaped the event.
6. Evaluate the performance's social purpose and your evidence for that claim.

The festival as a system, not a list of elements

A festival performance is organised the way a play is organised: it has a sequence, entrances, climaxes and a close. What changes is who controls the sequence. In a written play the playwright and director fix the order; in a festival the order is held by ritual knowledge, the calendar and the titled elders or priests who authorise each stage.

This is why a performance report that simply lists "drums, masquerades, dancing and singing" scores badly. A stronger report explains function: the drums cue the transition from the profane to the sacred phase; the masquerade marks the moment the ancestors are present; the dance pattern identifies which lineage group is hosting; the audience response signals whether the performance is accepted.

The festival also distributes roles in a way that resembles a production team. There are custodians of the shrine (comparable to a producer holding authority), performance leaders (director and choreographer), costumed and masked specialists (design and costume), musicians (sound and score) and the community (audience and chorus). Naming these parallels shows you understand theatre as an organised event rather than a collection of "culture".

> **A test for your own writing**
> For every element you mention, write "and therefore...". Drums, and therefore the mood shifts and the audience knows the phase has changed. If you cannot finish the sentence, cut the element.

Masquerade, secrecy and the ethics of description

The masquerade is not a costume worn by a performer for entertainment. In many communities the mask is the visible form of a presence - an ancestor, a deity, a social authority - and the identity of the wearer is protected by custom. This creates a real constraint on what an outsider may record and publish.

Academically, describe what the audience is permitted to see and what the community itself says about the figure. Do not attempt to unmask a performer in your writing, do not speculate about individuals, and do not photograph restricted moments. Ethics is part of method here, not an afterthought: a report that violates a community restriction is worthless as scholarship because the performance it describes will never be allowed to happen in front of a researcher again.

Use the community's own names for the figure and the festival. Where a translation is necessary, give the local term first and an approximate gloss in brackets, and note that the gloss is approximate. This small habit signals that you understand the difference between a translation and an equivalent.

Oral tradition as a script

An oral performance has a text, but the text is stored in memory, in music and in inherited formulas rather than on paper. That text is remarkably stable in structure and remarkably flexible in wording: the praise singer may improvise lines about a visitor, but the order of praise names and the sequence of the ceremony do not change.

This is directly comparable to formulaic composition in other traditions, and it is why "the play was not written down" does not mean "the play had no form". When you describe oral theatre, identify the fixed structure (the sequence of episodes) separately from the variable material (improvised praise, topical satire, audience interaction).

For analysis, use a transcription method: record with permission, transcribe with the help of a speaker of the language, mark the boundaries between song, speech and action, and note where the performer departed from the expected pattern. That transcription evidence is what turns an opinion about "rich oral tradition" into an argument.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 101

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 101 Traditional African Theatre (3 credits) described as non-written drama and festival-derived theatre in various African communities
- Emphasis on theatre "evolving from the festival in its various contexts and settings"
- No separate film-track foundation course listed at 100 level in this snapshot

What changed: The 2018 page frames the course almost entirely around festival and community contexts.

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 101 Traditional African Theatre, 3 credits, first semester, 100 level
- Course numbering: first digit = year, middle digits = stress area, last digits = serial
- Companion 100-level courses appear: THA 111, 131, 151, 153, 161, 112, 122, 132, 142, 152, 162

What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 122, THA 153 and THA 161 (Participation Orientation, 2 credits), which do not appear in the 2018 description.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- THA 101 remains the 100-level foundation in history and comparative theatre
- Department is now styled Theatre and Film Studies, so 100-level cohorts may take media-facing companions
- Confirm whether THA 161 Participation Orientation is still required in your own registration

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a performance you attended

You watched a masquerade festival in your town and must write a 500-word analysis. Here is the reasoning order that earns marks.

1. Open with the occasion: name the festival, the community, the date, and who authorised the performance. One sentence, no adjectives.
2. Describe the space in three sentences: where the audience stood, where the performance happened, and what that division allowed or prevented.
3. Trace the sequence in four beats - gathering, entry of the masked figures, the central action, the closing. Give beats, not a minute-by-minute diary.
4. Analyse two elements in depth rather than six in passing: music as a structural cue, and costume as an announcement of identity or rank.
5. Describe audience participation with evidence: when did people join, what did their joining change, who did not participate.
6. Close with the social function, phrased as a claim supported by what you saw, not as a slogan.

> **What to carry forward**
> Depth on two elements beats breadth on eight. An examiner can only award analysis for something you explained.

2. Comparing ritual and theatre without ranking them

A question asks you to distinguish ritual from theatre using one example each.

1. Define the criterion instead of the term: ritual is action whose primary purpose is to enact a required transformation; theatre is action presented for an audience whose primary purpose is to witness a fiction or a representation.
2. State the overlap immediately: both use costume, space, sequence, music and an audience, which is why the origin debate exists.
3. Give your ritual example (a naming ceremony, a burial rite) and identify its required outcome.
4. Give your theatre example (a staged play) and identify its framing - the agreed pretence that what is happening is representation.
5. Conclude with what the distinction buys you: it lets you describe African festival forms as theatre without denying their ritual work.

> **What to carry forward**
> Never define by absence ("ritual has no audience"). Define by purpose and framing, then admit the overlap.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. With reference to one Nigerian festival you have observed, discuss the claim that traditional African theatre is "total theatre".

20 marks - about 35 minutes

1. Introduce total theatre as the integration of space, music, dance, costume, mask, narrative and audience participation in one event; attribute the framing carefully to the scholarship you have read.
2. Name your festival and its community, season and authorising authority. One paragraph of context.
3. Take three elements and show how each carries meaning: music as cue and mood, costume/mask as identity, space as the boundary between ordinary and sacred.
4. Show the integration, not just the coexistence: how does a drum pattern change the costume's meaning? How does the audience response complete the performance?
5. Acknowledge the limitation of the concept: "total" can flatten differences between festival traditions and can imply a unity the participants themselves do not claim.
6. Conclude that the concept is useful as an analytical starting point, provided you keep the community's own account of the event in view.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Naming seven elements with no explanation of how they work together. That is description, not argument.

Q2. How does the masquerade tradition complicate the idea that theatre is a form of pretence?

15 marks

1. Set out the standard account: theatre involves an agreed pretence, with an actor playing a character.
2. Explain the masquerade's own claim: the figure is not a representation of a presence but a manifestation of it, which is why secrecy governs the performer's identity.
3. Identify the consequence for the audience: they are not suspending disbelief, they are participating in a belief system with obligations.
4. Discuss the scholarly problem: outsiders often describe masquerade as theatre, while insiders may reject that description as a category error.
5. Conclude with a defensible position: masquerade is performance and often theatrical in form, but "pretence" is the wrong frame for its own account of itself.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Dismissing the community's account as superstition. Describe the claim, then analyse it.

Q3. What does an oral performance lose and gain when it is written down?

15 marks

1. Define what writing fixes: wording, sequence, and a text that can travel without performers.
2. Identify what is lost: variation, responsiveness to the audience, the authority of the living performer, and the ritual occasion itself.
3. Identify what is gained: preservation, wider circulation, teachability, and the possibility of close textual analysis.
4. Use one example - a transcribed praise poem or a published festival account - and show a specific feature that the transcription cannot carry, such as tone, timing or audience response.
5. Conclude that transcription is a translation between media, and should be read with the method of the transcriber in view.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Total theatre. A performance mode in which space, music, movement, costume, mask and audience participation operate together as one system of meaning.

Ritual. A prescribed sequence of actions performed to bring about a required transformation, such as purification, initiation or thanksgiving.

Masquerade. A costumed and masked performance figure whose identity is protected by custom and whose appearance often marks a sacred or judicial moment.

Oral tradition. Knowledge and performance text transmitted through memory, apprenticeship and recitation rather than writing.

Performance space. The physical and social area in which a performance happens, including the boundary between performers and audience.

Call and response. A structural pattern in which a lead voice or drummer states a phrase and the group answers, organising participation and timing.

Communal performance. Performance in which the community is not a passive audience but a participant with defined roles and obligations.

Festival calendar. The seasonal schedule that determines when a performance may take place, often tied to harvest, planting or ritual cycles.

Proscenium. A stage framed by an arch that separates performers from spectators, associated with illusionistic European theatre.

Dramatic text. The composed verbal structure of a play, whether written or held in memory, as distinct from a particular production.

Custodian. A person or lineage holding ritual authority over a performance, its space and its rules of access.

Ethnographic description. Description of a cultural practice grounded in observation and the community's own account, with the researcher's method stated.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Build the vocabulary

Definitions you can defend in a sentence.

- Write your own definitions of ritual, festival, theatre and performance.
- Collect three festival examples with community, season and function.
- Attend or watch one recorded festival and take structured notes.

Week 2 - Analyse one event

Depth on two elements.

- Describe the performance space in a labelled diagram.
- Trace four beats of the event.

- Analyse music and costume with evidence, not adjectives.

Week 3 - Write under time

Exam-shaped practice.

- Answer the total-theatre question in 35 minutes without notes.
- Mark it against the outline in this pack.
- Rewrite the weakest paragraph only.

Week 4 - Consolidate

Recall and ethics.

- Recite the glossary terms and give an example for each.
- Re-read your performance report for unevidenced claims.
- Take two specific questions to your lecturer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Ogunba, O. - The Movement of Transition: a study of the plays of Wole Soyinka (festival and ritual framing).
- Adedeji, J. - writing on the Alarinjo travelling theatre tradition.
- Soyinka, W. - Myth, Literature and the African World, the essay usually cited as "The Fourth Stage".
- Any departmental course outline for THA 101: read the set texts before the lecture, not after.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is traditional African theatre often described as total theatre?

Answer: Because music, dance, costume, mask, space and audience participation operate together as one performance system rather than as separate additions.

2. Give two social functions of a festival performance.

Answer: Harvest thanksgiving and rite-of-passage initiation; purification and conflict resolution are also common.

3. What is the danger of treating masquerade as mere entertainment?

Answer: It removes the spiritual, judicial and social meanings the masquerade carries for the community, producing a shallow and inaccurate account.

4. How does the performance space shape meaning?

Answer: A shrine, market square or compound carries its own associations and determines sightlines, participation and the intimacy of the event.

5. Name three elements you would describe in a performance report.

Answer: The space, the costumes and masks, and the music or movement patterns.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write definitions of traditional theatre, ritual and festival in your own words.
- [ ] Attend or watch a recorded Nigerian festival performance and take structured notes.
- [ ] Draw a diagram of the performance space and annotate how it was used.
- [ ] Identify three ways the audience participated.
- [ ] Write a 300-word performance description with evidence for each claim.
- [ ] Read one article on African festival theatre and note its main argument.
- [ ] Take your performance report to a senior colleague for feedback.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

THA 101: Traditional African Theatre - Festival, Ritual and Performance